

MUSIC

AND THE BEAT **GOES ON**

New Delhi's Peter Cat Recording Co., whose 2019 album *Bismillah* received rave reviews both in India and abroad, hope that their upcoming US tour is a step towards bigger things

After a decade of slow grind in the Indian rock underground, New Delhi's Peter Cat Recording Co. were finally gathering steam in 2020. The band's woozy, genre-blending sound, refined over a series of independently released records and freewheeling live shows, had earned them a record deal with Parisian boutique label Panache a couple of years earlier. *Bismillah*, their first album on the label, dropped in 2019 to rave reviews domestically and internationally. They were busy lining up a European tour when a deadly new virus hit the headlines, throwing their—and the world's—plans onto the rubbish pile.

The band decided to lick their Covid-inflicted wounds in Goa, where they worked on new music and bided their time. But the eccentric soundscapes of *Bismillah* defied all lockdowns. The album found fans around the world, so much so that they caught the attention of American talent agency William Morris Endeavor (WME), which asked them to sign on for a US tour. Four years after *Bismillah*, the band will now take the record across the US, playing 29 shows on its American Spring '23 tour. "[WME] saw that we had started doing some good numbers during the pandemic in America," says Suryakant Sawhney, the band's frontman. In fact, as their publicist says, the US is now Peter Cat's largest market in terms of online listenership.

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The tour includes a slot at the BottleRock festival in California, where they'll play alongside iconic bands like The Smashing Pumpkins, The National and Duran Duran. Peter Cat is certainly not the first Indian group to do an American tour—Diljit Dosanjh just performed at Coachella, and Prateek Kuhad is one of the other artistes who have done it before—but it's still an achievement, especially for a group that has essentially bootstrapped its way to the big time. With 25 of the 29 dates already sold out—some within minutes—the band hopes the tour is a stepping stone to bigger things.

"We're trying to build a touring circuit that works for us, in a way that's only possible now because of the way music propagates," says Sawhney. "It's still very difficult to tour abroad, but if you build a real fanbase of people who will buy tickets, then you can make it work. We want to normalise the idea that we're just a band playing shows for our fans, and we just happen to live in India." After the tour, the band hopes to stay back in Los Angeles for a month and work on their next album. There are other tours being planned in the background, but the focus is on a follow-up to *Bismillah*.

"I think it's a really ambitious album," says Sawhney of the upcoming record. "We're not in the habit of repeating ourselves sonically, and this time there's the added pressure to top *Bismillah*. We really think we are going to set a new benchmark with this one." ■

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